BJP's policy of being soft to the Hindu immigrants and hard on the Muslim immigrants did not find many takers among influential section of Assamese society, who were more obsessed with the fear of domination by the Bengalis—both Hindus and Muslims—in all public spheres. Fear that their language and culture would be wiped out and the Assamese people would become minorities in their own land drove them to the so-called 'anti-foreigners' movement in the late seventies.

In the 1980s, the RSS started supporting the Assam movement, and this is what created an initial platform for the BJP. Its backing, the journalist Shekhar Gupta has argued, helped change the 'national imagery of the Assam movement, which was seen as anti-national because it blockaded crude supplies to the mainland'.[154] This meant that many of the movement's leaders, who later created the AGP, the state's pre-eminent regional party, started seeing the Sangh as an ally. In turn, the RSS, which had always opposed Muslim migration but not Hindu refugees from Bangladesh, gradually succeeded in shifting the popular focus from 'anti-immigrant to anti-Muslim immigrant'.[155] In this formulation, Hindu immigrants became 'sharnarthee', or asylum-seekers, while Muslim migrants became classified as 'anupraveshkaari', or infiltrators who had to be sent back.[156] RSS leaders like the late Bansilal Soni and Padmanabha Acharya (later appointed governor, first of Nagaland, then additionally of Tripura and Assam, and also given charge briefly of Arunachal Pradesh and Manipur) were among those who worked to lay this foundation. By the time L.K. Advani began his Ayodhya Rath Yatra, the 'BJP in Assam had a strong platform'.[157] It won its first Lok Sabha seat in 1991. A number of cadres from the AGP, the political successor to the Assam movement, started moving to the BJP around this time. It gave the party new local leadership and credibility over and above its old Sangh base. 'Wherever Assamese Hindus were unhappy, BJP started growing. Now they portray themselves as saviours of Assamese Hindus,' explained a local editor.[158]